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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 19, 2025 • \$6

Pair from boat attack are being repatriated

Alleged traffickers are first survivors of U.S. strikes tied to Venezuela

BY ALEX HORTON
AND TARA COPP

The United States is repatriating two alleged drug traffickers to Colombia and Ecuador after military forces attacked their vessel in the Caribbean Sea on Thursday, President Donald Trump said.

Facing questions about the legality of the strikes, the Trump administration has sought to justify the killing of more than two dozen since the operations began last month by claiming the U.S. is in “armed conflict” with Latin American drug cartels that are linked to Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro’s effort to dispatch drugs and criminals to the U.S.

Trump said two other alleged traffickers were killed in the strike, and the two survivors would be returned to their home countries “for detention and prosecution.”

Colombian President Gustavo Petro said the country received the Colombian national on Saturday, expressing relief he was alive and that any potential prosecution would be handled according to law. It was not immediately clear when the Ecuadorian national would be repatriated. They did not have serious injuries from the strike, said three people familiar with the matter, speaking on the condition of anonymity to discuss a sensitive operation.

SEE VENEZUELA ON A13

Therapies for microplastics are here, but do they work?

BY SHANNON OSAKA
AND DANIEL GILBERT

As Mike Petegorsky prepared to welcome his baby daughter, he worked to minimize his family’s exposure to microplastics and other environmental toxins. The telehealth executive got rid of plastic Tupperware and utensils. He had a whole-house water filter installed. But every effort gave way to a feeling of futility.

“If we can’t prevent it from getting into our bodies,” Petegorsky wondered, “can we get it out?”

There is mounting evidence that microplastics and “forever chemicals” are infiltrating human bodies and endangering people’s health. Microplastics have been found in key arteries, the gut, the liver and the brain. Forever chemicals, also known as per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances (PFAS), can lurk in the body for more than a decade, spurring fertility problems and cancer.

Petegorsky’s quest eventually led him to Switzerland, where he underwent a treatment in May 2024 that drew his blood and filtered out tiny foreign particles. He felt a humming sensation, took a nap in the middle of the outpatient procedure — and saw the makings of a new business. Teaming up with medical-device entrepreneur Carlos Schuster, the duo formed Proxima Health to license the device made by Basel-based Ayus Medical Group and

SEE MICROPLASTICS ON A24

Big crowds protest Trump across U.S.



JOSHUA LOTT/THE WASHINGTON POST

Javier Villalobos joins demonstrators Saturday in Chicago, a focal point of the Trump administration’s crackdown on illegal immigration.



PETER W. STEVENSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

Demonstrators in downtown Washington rally Saturday. The mass gatherings remained largely peaceful through early Saturday night.



OLGA FEDOROVA/AP

Protesters in New York hold a U.S. flag upside down Saturday. Organizers arranged protests in some 2,600 locations.

Ukraine must give up all of Donetsk region, Putin tells Trump

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

Russian President Vladimir Putin in a phone call this past week with President Donald Trump demanded that Kyiv surrender full control of Donetsk, a strategically vital region in eastern Ukraine, as a condition for ending the war, said two senior officials familiar with the conversation.

Putin has tried and failed to conquer the territory for 11 years, repeatedly repulsed by Ukrainian

forces who are deeply entrenched in an area they believe is a major bulwark against a speedy Russian advance westward toward their capital.

Putin’s focus on Donetsk suggests he is not backing away from past demands that have left the conflict in a stalemate, despite Trump’s optimism about securing a deal, the officials said, speaking on the condition of anonymity to describe sensitive closed-door discussions. Russia or Russian-

backed separatists have claimed parts of the region since 2014, but they have never been able to conquer the entirety of the region by force.

Trump has not publicly commented on Putin’s demand for all of Donetsk, which has not previously been reported. Trump did not endorse the Russian request in his public statement Friday after a high-stakes West Wing meeting with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky. He plans to

meet Putin in Hungary in the coming weeks to continue discussions about how to end the war.

“It is time to stop the killing, and make a DEAL! Enough blood has been shed, with property lines being defined by War and Guts. They should stop where they are. Let both claim Victory, let History decide!” Trump wrote on social media Friday after the meeting with Zelensky.

In the call between Trump and Putin, the Russian leader suggest-

ed he would be willing to surrender parts of two other regions of Ukraine he has partly conquered, Zaporizhzhia and Kherson, in exchange for full control of Donetsk, the officials said. That is slightly less of a sweeping territorial claim than he made in August at a summit between Trump and Putin in Anchorage. Some White House

SEE PUTIN ON A15

Trump’s many shifts: A call with Putin changed his mind. Again. **A18**



MAXINE WALLACE/THE WASHINGTON POST

Lavender Timmons, executive director of Evansville Recovery Alliance, collects used needles in Evansville, Indiana, in August.

Needle exchanges at risk of vanishing

Drug-safety programs have saved lives, but funding is in Trump’s crosshairs

BY DAVID OVALLE
AND MAXINE WALLACE

EVANSVILLE, IND. — Lavender Timmons popped the trunk of her weather-beaten 2007 Ford Focus parked near the city’s homeless shelter. Regulars gathered around, including one drug user who in the past bought sterile syringes from the illicit market.

Timmons, executive director of Evansville Recovery Alliance, wanted to offer them new needles to keep them from contracting HIV, hepatitis C or other infections. But a police car idled a couple blocks away.

“The cops are watching us,” Timmons said.

A decade after users injecting prescription painkillers sparked a historic HIV outbreak in a southern Indiana county, programs providing sterile needles that contained the crisis are fading. They may disappear completely next year — and nationwide, they are also in peril. The Trump administration has declared that no federal funding can go toward supplies that “promote or facilitate drug use” — even though decades of research has shown that syringe programs reduce disease transmission rates and do not appear

to increase injection frequency or neighborhood crime rates.

Evansville has never authorized needle exchanges. Advocates, such as Timmons, who have lobbied for needle exchanges are losing hope — even as fentanyl and methamphetamine users continue to inject with used needles. Under state law, a county health officer must first declare an HIV or hepatitis C emergency — and there is not enough testing to quantify the need, Timmons said, despite some support from local officials.

In Indiana, possessing a syringe is a crime. **SEE SYRINGES ON A6**

SPORTS

Basketball’s next big thing is led by a sports dad like no other. **B1**

BUSINESS

Never mind the “lipstick index”: Check out these recession signs. **B11**



BOOK WORLD

Modern woes in ancient Polynesia color Adam Johnson’s new novel.

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Despite millions spent to fight it, truancy in D.C. Public Schools is up. **B18**



TRAVEL

A grim economic outlook is challenging Hawaii’s “regenerative” tourism.

ARTS & STYLE

Meet a symphony oboist who became a classical music #MeToo vigilante.

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